

The Obligation Mosaic: Race and Social Norms in US Political Participation

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CHAPTER

Five Taking Care of Those in Need

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Abstract

Prosocial behaviors like helping others are central to human society. But there are many ways to help—including through political participation. Do racial groups in the United States vary in the degree to which they connect political activity, versus charitable or religious activity, to the helping hands norm? Differences in racial group status, experiences with structural disadvantage, and the broader system of racial hierarchy in the United States suggest that different groups may tie political participation to helping at varying rates. Using survey data from the four largest racial groups in the United States—Asian, Black, Latino, and White Americans—findings show that a normative commitment to help those in need is common in the United States and varies moderately in its connection to political participation by racial group membership. Further, in-group racial embeddedness with respect to the composition of census block, close social ties, and group closeness moderate this connection.

Keywords: [prosocial](#), [helping behavior](#), [status](#), [racial hierarchy](#), [structural disadvantage](#), [political participation](#), [social ties](#), [census block](#), [group closeness](#), [political helping index](#)

Subject: [US Politics](#)

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A commitment to helping those in need was a common thread in my discussions with Black and Asian Americans across the country who often identified helping behaviors as a core component of self, career, and relationship to family and society. A prescriptive commitment to help those in need intersected with political participation for some I talked with, drawing it to my attention as a norm with relevance for politics. The primary way these individuals helped those in need was by engaging in the political arena to change policy. Black Americans, more than Asian Americans, discussed this interpretation of the helping hands norm and described how their choices to help others in this way were often rewarded and reinforced by their community.

In this chapter, I use empirical data from the Participatory Social Norms Survey to examine the strength of the helping hands norm in the United States and its behavioral variations across racial groups. I begin by diving into a robust literature in social psychology that examines why, when, and how people help one another. Combining this literature with insights from the qualitative interviews presented in chapter 3, I develop a set of hypotheses about why racial groups in the United States might vary with respect to this particular norm. Specifically, I argue that differences in experiences with and perceptions of structural disadvantage that vary systematically across groups shape beliefs about the causes of need in the United States and the norms that emerge around solutions. In line with the racialized norms model, group-based norms with respect to helping behavior should be clearest in segregated contexts where the signal and enforcement of norms are strongest.

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Developing and examining unique empirical measures of the helping hands norm, I find that a prescriptive commitment to helping those in need is widely endorsed in the United States but that both the strength of the norm and how one goes about complying with it vary moderately across racial groups. Black Americans both exhibit stronger commitments to the helping hands norm in general and are more likely to couple the norm with participatory behaviors. Furthermore, social and psychological coracial embeddedness increases the strength of a participatory commitment to the norm for this group. Other racial minorities, too, show some increased coupling of the norm with participatory behaviors compared to Whites, and racial embeddedness again influences the strength and direction of this connection.

The collective evidence suggests that political participation is a behavior sometimes connected to the helping hands norm and that the propensity to make this connection varies somewhat across groups. Yet the magnitude of this cross-group variation is significantly smaller than we observed for the honoring ancestors norm in the previous chapter. The findings suggest, then, that while a political expression of the helping hands norm may influence an individual's propensity to engage in politics, it may be less important for explaining cross-group variation in participation compared to the political ancestors norm.

The When, Why, and How of Helping Behavior

The beauty of the scientific method lies in its ability to create unbiased knowledge, but scientists themselves are far from dispassionate observers. Their choices about how to apply the scientific method—which questions to ask, which measures to use, how to interpret results—reflect everything from the epistemology of their discipline to personal life experiences. As a result, when salient events occur, including war, recession, or protest, the whole trajectory of a discipline can change suddenly as a new set of questions captures the attention of scientists all at once.

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This is what happened in the wake of World War II. As the Allied powers made headway against the German forces in the mid-1940s, Soviet, American, and British troops began to uncover mass graves and concentration camps, informing the world of the genocide that had occurred. Millions of German officials, soldiers, and citizens it turned out had systematically tortured and killed the young, the elderly, and the disabled alike. Shocked and horrified, moral theorists and social scientists were left wondering how seemingly ordinary people were convinced to do such terrible things. A burgeoning field of research emerged on *antisocial behavior*, or acts of hostility and violence against others (Ross, Lepper, and Ward, 2010). This research revealed a complicated mix of dispositional and situational factors that led many people to obedience, even under conditions that clearly made them uncomfortable. In some of the most well-known studies ever conducted in the social sciences, scholars began to understand and explain the “banality of evil” (Adorno, 1950; Arendt, 1963; Zimbardo et al., 1971; Milgram, 1963).

As work on antisocial behavior proliferated through the midcentury, some scholars responded by challenging science to think not just about why people do bad things but also why they do good. Stories emerged about those who hid the persecuted and aided in the escape of strangers during the Holocaust, putting their own lives

on the line for the sake of others (Monroe, 2013; Oliner and Oliner, 1988). These scholars argued that doing good was not simply the opposite of doing bad, as some had previously assumed. Rather, *prosocial* behavior had its own origins, pushing some individuals from neutrality to altruism and self-sacrifice. On the heels of the antisocial literature, a prosocial scholarship was born as scientists across disciplines began to map the why, when, and how of helping behavior (Batson, 1998; Dovidio, 1984; Penner et al., 2005).

To a lay observer, the question of why some people help others may seem to have an obvious answer: because it is the right thing to do, clearly. But for social scientists, this question challenged a central assumption held widely in economics, political science, and psychology at the time: that people are fundamentally motivated by their own self-interest (Mansbridge, 1990; Monroe, 1994). Theories of human behavior often hinged on the belief that people were universally motivated by the desire to increase their personal well-being, especially with respect to material resources; attitudes and actions followed from this singular goal. But if people were prosocial, sometimes engaging in acts of altruism or even self-sacrifice, what did this mean for the foundational assumption of humans as self-interested actors?

This question led many to quibble over whether human action was ever, really, self-sacrificing, but natural scientists skipped this theoretical conundrum entirely. Informed by the theory of natural selection, these scholars asked, What evolutionary advantage might prosocial behavior produce or be the product of? From this work, an evolutionary theory of prosocial behavior emerged, one that helped explain the crosscultural tendency to help others (Batson, 1998). Individuals are more likely to survive and reproduce when they can cooperate with and anticipate the actions of others, evidence suggested, and so tools that aid in this process proliferate (Dawkins, 1976; Iacoboni, 2009; Petersen, 2011; Wilson, 2000). Empathy may be one such tool, allowing people to literally feel and mirror the thinking and emotions of those around them (Batson and Coke, 1981; Iacoboni, 2009). Research suggests that when observing others in need, many experience psychological distress in response, which can prompt them to action (Batson, 1998; Betancourt, 1990; Dovidio, 1984).

Evolutionary theory then, can help explain the *why* of helping behavior but not necessarily the *when*. Psychological tension following the observation of someone in need provides a prerequisite for helping behavior, as once a person feels this tension, he or she is motivated to resolve it and can do so through prosocial, helping behavior (Batson, 1998; Dovidio, 1984). But there are alternatives. Some will choose to flee, escaping the situation and person all together if the opportunity presents itself (Batson, 1998; Darley and Batson, 1973). Others will provide aid, although this can take on a variety of forms (Diekmann and Clark, 2015; Gilligan, 1993; Luria, Cnaan, and Boehm, 2014). Still others will see their distress transform into contempt and blame the person in need for the situation (Batson, 1998).

To understand when a person's psychological tension will manifest in helping behavior, we must turn to the social features of a situation. This turn from universal predisposition to contextualized behavior should be a familiar one by now. In the previous chapter, we learned the desire to honor the past is a near universal concept, appearing in countries, cultures, and religions across the world, but how one goes about honoring the past is highly context dependent. Helping behavior seems to follow a similar pattern. Many humans experience psychological tension when observing someone in need, but deciding how to act following this emotional response is heavily driven by context. Beliefs about who is deserving of help, situational factors that distract or allow for easy escape, and past experiences that systematically vary across groups all drive an individual's propensity to decide whether and how to help (Batson, 1998; Darley and Batson, 1973; Diekmann and Clark, 2015; Gilens, 2009; Wright, 2001). A basic neurological predisposition to feel tension when observing someone in need is followed by an environmentally influenced reaction regarding whether helping is the appropriate response to the observed situation.

So what are the contextual features that lead someone to help versus resolve their psychological tension some other way? Timing and ease of escape are two important factors (Batson, 1998; Darley and Batson, 1973), but so too are beliefs about the attributes of the person needing help and the cause of his or her situation (Betancourt,

1990; Petersen, 2011; Ross, 1977). Research has shown that if an individual believes a person's distress is caused by his or her own doing—that is, the person either has dispositional flaws like laziness or has made bad choices leading to his or her need—a potential helper is more likely to reject the needy person. In contrast, if the problem is perceived as caused by the situation—say, a structural malfunction or bad luck outside of the person's control—then empathy is more likely to follow, leading to helping behavior. Beliefs about worthiness and the cause of one's problems determine whether an individual responds to a person in need with empathy and prosocial action or contempt and rejection (Betancourt, 1990; McMahon, Wernsman, and Parnes, 2006).

Unlike the predisposition to help itself, the manifestation of *attribution*, then, is far from unified. But neither is it random. Structural features of a society or group that shape exposure to need or beliefs about agency can create group-level patterns in attributional tendencies (Wright, 2001; Zucker and Weiner, 1993). Research suggests that personal experiences with suffering as well as occupying a low-status position can lead to greater empathy and a higher propensity toward prosocial action under certain circumstances (Gilens, 2009; Piff et al., 2010; Vollhardt, 2009).¹ Perceived similarity between oneself and the person in need also triggers stronger empathetic reactions and an increased propensity to help (Fowler and Kam, 2007; Penner et al., 2005; Sirin, Valentino, and Villalobos, 2016a, 2016b). Macrostructural features of a society that unequally distribute resources, create inequalities in exposure to injustice, or build status differences between groups, then, can lead to systematic variations in the perceived causes of need.

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Not only are beliefs about attribution context dependent, but so too are the actions individuals choose to engage in when trying to help others (Brickman et al., 1982). *How* one helps, that is, once one has decided to do so, is shaped by the opportunities and constraints imposed by society and the situation. Men and women, for instance, have been shown to help differently, with their behaviors reflecting the skills and social roles imposed upon them (Diekman and Clark, 2015; Gilligan, 1993). Structural constraints with respect to the pathways available for helping also influence the form of prosocial behavior. Volunteering, for instance, is possible only in societies with robust civic organizations (Luria, Cnaan, and Boehm, 2014). The menu of options in America ranges from direct and voluntary organizational assistance to structural change (Poppendieck, 1999), but context affects one's choice.

Because beliefs about the causes of need are responsive to structural elements of society and opportunities to provide aid are similarly constrained by structural forces, descriptive norms about what the average person thinks and how he or she acts can diverge based on group membership. If benefits exist to sustain these descriptive norms, then prescriptive norms are likely to follow (Morris et al., 2015). Beliefs about deservingness and the behaviors associated with helping transform into group-level social norms that are defined, justified, and reinforced over time by the micro mechanisms of social expectation, socialization, and elite framing. Those socially embedded in a group, or highly identified with its members, will be more likely to conform to these norms (Conover, 1988; Huddy, 2013), and with enough reinforcement, external norms are integrated into core concepts of self and morality, leading to the rise of powerful personal norms (Batson, 1998; Schwartz, 1977; Thøgersen, 2006).

Thus, much like the honoring ancestors norm, the tendency to help people in need likely has its foundation in evolutionary biology, but the exact ways people help others and the conditions for action are group specific and highly variable. The selection of genes that lubricate social relations gives rise to a broad, psychological predisposition to feel empathy and help others, shared by many around the globe. But the specific content of the *helping hands norm*—who is deserving, how best to help—mirrors the contextual features of a group. Macrostructural forces constrain the development of these norms, but group members have agency in defining their essence and maintaining their cohesion.

Expectations about Variation in Helping Behavior

p. 103 Extant theory on prosocial behavior suggests that normative commitments to help those in need are widespread, but the *when* and *how* of helping behavior is variable. My qualitative work in chapter 3 suggested that variation might exist across groups in the propensity to link political participation to the helping hands norm. Black Americans were more likely than Asian Americans to identify political involvement, especially localized and grassroots political activity, as a way to help those in need. Asian Americans were more likely to identify individual acts of generosity. My analysis of these interviews suggested that differences stemmed from variation in individual-level material status and individual-and group-level exposure to injustice; the prosocial literature confirms that this may be the case, highlighting how these factors likely affect beliefs about the structural causes of need and influence prosocial responses. We can use these insights to develop a set of hypotheses about how and why political participation as a helping behavior may vary across racial groups in the United States.

When discussing why and how they help, many Black Americans I interviewed cited their own experiences with poverty, racial injustice, and violence—or mentioned the experiences of those close to them. Tisha provides an example. A Black woman and resident of Oakland, Tisha discussed the murder of her childhood friend, the poor representation her father received in a trial for attempted robbery, and her time spent in foster care when I asked about her decision to pursue a law degree. These experiences shaped her interest in working for policy change in the criminal justice system. “I came in with the goal of being a youth lawyer,” she said, but now, “a lot of people are trying to push me into going into politics.... I want to effect change on the policy level, because that’s really where the change happens in terms of laws.”

Scholars have long documented the ways that Black Americans are “disadvantaged and devalued” compared to Whites, who “are positioned as the dominant and most advantaged group in American society” (Zou and Cheryan, 2017, 696; see also Hochschild, Weaver, and Burch, 2012; Masuoka and Junn, 2013; Pettit, 2012; Sidanius and Pratto, 1999). This position in the racial hierarchy affects the treatment of Black Americans across a wide range of economic, political, and legal institutions (Alexander, 2012; Pager, 2003; Sidanius and Pratto, 1999) and manifests in striking income and wealth gaps. As of 2017, the median Black household was estimated to have \$28,000 less in income and \$100,000 less in assets than its non-Hispanic White counterpart (Fontenot, Semega, and Kollar, 2018; Kochhar and Fry, 2014). Furthermore, Black Americans report a high level of discrimination centered around their perceived social and intellectual worth (Zou and Cheryan, 2017).

p. 104 The fact that Black Americans, as a group, are situated lower in the American racial hierarchy, are more likely to experience poverty firsthand or through proximal means, and face continuing constraints with respect to the perceived porousness of their group likely affect the average group member’s beliefs about why people are in need and the best ways to help them. Experimental research in social psychology has shown that awareness of one’s low status shifts beliefs about desert (Piff et al., 2010) and that individuals who experience suffering or injustice respond more empathetically when observing others in parallel situations (Sirin, Valentino, and Villalobos, 2016b; Vollhardt, 2009). These factors should produce an observable group-level pattern among Black Americans with regard to the causes of need in the United States. Indeed, evidence from the General Social Survey (GSS) suggests that Black Americans are more likely than Whites to believe coming from a wealthy family is key to getting ahead in America, are less likely to believe hard work alone leads to success, and more commonly cite racial discrimination as the cause of Black social and economic status.²

An increased likelihood to see need as the product of structural malfunction may lead Black Americans not only to attitudes that encourage redistributive policies (Dawson, 2003; Gilens, 2009) but also to helping behaviors aimed at changing what is perceived as an unjust political system (Brickman et al., 1982). Social identity theory suggests that when the boundaries of groups are tightly constrained, the most well-off members of low-status groups will press for social change (Tajfel and Turner, 1986). This dynamic is well

captured in my interview with DeMarkus, a Tennessee resident who works on a college campus. He and his wife have advanced degrees, collectively make six figures, and own their home. He told me, “I promise you, if I had all the stuff I needed and I was sure that my family was gonna have for the next few years, I might not give two cares about this political system. I may not care, ‘cause I have that privilege and that luxury. And I kind of have it now, a little bit. [But] I’m still Black. That’s the only problem.” Even middle- and upper-class Black Americans, then—individuals who make up a growing segment of the population (Hochschild, Weaver, and Burch, 2012)—may tie the helping hands norm to political participation. Group elites, too, may actively tie political activity to norms about helping those in need as a way of advancing group interests.

p. 105 Societal constraints in the form of Black Americans’ minority status in a majoritarian democracy may further shape the expression of the helping hands norm. Politically oriented helping behavior may be channeled into local electoral politics, where minority groups sometimes make up a larger share of the voting population (Hajnal and Trounstein, 2005), and into nonvoting political activities, which do not require access from a gatekeeper (Gillion, 2013). Thus, while we are likely to observe a number of behaviors associated with helping those in need—reflecting the proliferation of charitable, religious, and direct service options—Black Americans might be more likely than others groups to name political activism that is local or nonelectoral as a way to address need in the United States.

In contrast, a consideration of group status and experiences with disadvantage suggests that White Americans, on average, may be less likely to connect the helping hands norm to political activism. White Americans have dominated the top of the racial hierarchy for as long as the nation has existed (Haney Lopez, 2006; Masuoka and Junn, 2013; Omi and Winant, 2014), and a smaller percentage of White Americans live below the poverty line than any other racial group (Fontenot, Semega, and Kollar, 2018). This positioning likely affects beliefs about the causes of and solutions for need. Humans are inclined to down-weight situational factors when explaining others’ behavior (Ross, 1977; Ross, Amabile, and Steinmetz, 1977), ascribe success to self but disappointments to external causes (Bradley, 1978; Pettigrew, 1979), and assign trait-based explanations for need to out-groups (Hewstone, 1990). These proclivities assist in a process of justifying White social, political, and economic domination, attitudes that are further crystallized and activated by elites (Gilens, 2009; Mendelberg, 2001).

Others have shown that many White Americans identify helping people in need as normatively important but believe that the government is likely to help those who are undeserving (Cramer, 2016; Katz, 2013)—namely, Black people (Bobo and Kluegel, 1993; Gilens, 2009; Snowden and Graaf, 2019). Evidence from the GSS shows that White Americans, on average, rate Black people as significantly lazier than their in-group.³ Those inclined to help, as a result, may turn to prosocial behaviors where the recipient of the help is more closely within their direct control, like charitable giving or volunteering. However, a connection between the helping hands norm and politics may diverge significantly by partisanship for White Americans, with Democrats more likely to perceive structural disadvantage and seek political solutions for need as a result.

p. 106 Work on the racial hierarchy in the United States generally situates Latinos and Asian Americans between White and Black Americans— although the arrangement of these two groups relative to each other depends on the scholar (e.g., Lee, 2005; Masuoka and Junn, 2013; Zou and Cheryan, 2017). Asian Americans have, on average, the highest level of yearly family income of the four largest racial groups in the United States and are lauded as a “model minority” (Fontenot, Semega, and Kollar, 2018; Junn, 2008). With their socioeconomic status framed as reflecting positive, internal traits of the group’s members, Asian Americans are commonly placed in juxtaposition to Black Americans—by White elites but also by Asian Americans themselves—despite radically different group histories (Junn, 2008; Masuoka and Junn, 2013; Osajima, 2005; Paek and Shah, 2003; Wong et al., 1998; Wong and Halgin, 2006).⁴

These factors may lead Asian Americans, on average, to situate the causes of need in the dispositions of individuals rather than in structural malfunction, leading to helping behaviors expressed through means other

than politics. However, I expect this pattern to be tempered compared to White Americans. Many have argued that the model-minority myth produces a number of negative externalities, including the continuation of the perception of Asian Americans as “forever foreigners,” a stereotype that has historically constrained the political and economic rights of Asian Americans (Junn, 2008; Lee, 2005; Takaki, 2008; Wong and Halgin, 2006; Wong et al., 2011). Jonathan, a medical student at an elite private university I interviewed, echoed the social science research on this topic. He explained, “The model-minority myth, in a lot of ways, in really kind of bad ways, has been internalized by the Asian American community as a form of flattery, even though it’s used as a cultural bludgeon.... They said, ‘Oh, see these Japanese Americans and these Chinese Americans, they don’t need rights, ’cause they have good family values, and hard work, and focus on education.’... Bill O’Reilly used [this line of reasoning] last week.” As a result, members of this group who are highly aware of their minority status and see commonality across Asian Americans may be more likely to identify political activism as a way to help those in need.

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Latinos similarly face ambiguity in status. Noting the categorization of Latino/Hispanic as an ethnicity rather than a race on official government forms like the US Census and efforts to incorporate Latinos into conservative, primarily White coalitions, some have argued that this racial group in particular is more poorly defined in the United States, leading to porousness and attempts to “Whiten” its members (Beltrán, 2010; Gans, 2012; Mora, 2014; Waterston, 2006). Others argue that the focus on immigration policy in the United States along with the recent criminalization of border crossings is increasingly racializing the group and defining the experiences of even third-, fourth-, and fifth-generation Latinos (Jiménez, 2010; Waters and Kasinitz, 2015). As a result, some theoretical models position Latinos between Black and White Americans at a level commensurate with Asian Americans, while others place them below both Asian Americans and Whites but above Black Americans (e.g., Lee, 2005; Masuoka and Junn, 2013; Omi and Winant, 2014).

Regardless of their potential status as honorary Whites, Latinos in the United States more closely resemble Black Americans with respect to poverty and resources. Thirteen percent of Latinos in the United States have at least a bachelor’s degree, compared to 29% of Whites and 18% of Blacks (Ogunwole, Drewery, and Rios-Vargas, 2012). Furthermore, an estimated 18% of Latinos live below the poverty line, 3% fewer than Black Americans but almost 10% more than White Americans (Fontenot, Semega, and Kollar, 2018). Evidence suggests that Latinos are more likely than Asian Americans or Whites to experience discrimination and stereotyping with respect to their perceived cultural, economic, and intellectual qualities (Zou and Cheryan, 2017). The relatively low levels of socioeconomic resources among Latinos combined with the racialization of the group should lead to stronger helping hands norms compared to White Americans and a stronger propensity to situationalize poverty, leading to grassroots political action rather than charitable solutions to American need. However, this commitment may be tempered compared to Black Americans, with more heterogeneity within the group.

My expectations about variations in the helping hands norm are displayed visually in figure 5.1. The figure arrays groups along a continuum that encompasses positioning with respect to experiences with and perceptions of structural disadvantage, based on extant literature and hypotheses about the likelihood of expressing the helping hands norm through political involvement below. White Americans are situated to the far left of the spectrum, reflecting how the group’s high status and resources are expected to produce a weak connection between the helping hands norm and political participation. Black Americans, in contrast, are situated on the opposite end of the spectrum, reflecting their historical anchoring at the bottom of the American racial hierarchy and beliefs about the structural disadvantage targeted at their group.

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Asian Americans and Latinos are centrally arranged between these two groups, with Asian Americans shifted slightly to the left of the continuum. While I expect all three minority groups to be more likely than White Americans to connect the helping hands norm to political involvement, especially grassroots action that is local and system challenging and champions community-based leadership, this commitment should be tempered among Latinos and Asian Americans, for whom the boundaries of racial group are more porous. ↵

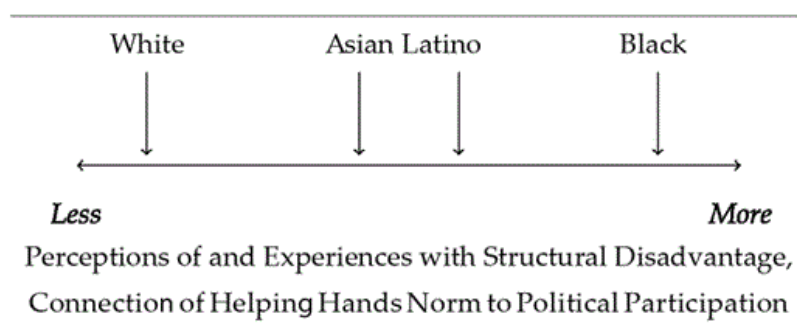


Figure 5.1 Expected group variability in the helping hands norm

Commitments to and Expressions Of Helping Others

Having defined specific expectations about the direction and strength of the helping hands norms in the United States, I turn to testing these hypotheses using the PSNS. This data set includes a novel four-item battery designed to measure prescriptive commitments to helping the needy. Each respondent in the PSNS was asked to think about “those in need. This might include people who are struggling to get by or are experiencing hardship,” then indicate the degree to which they agreed or disagreed (0–4) with four randomly presented statements:

- Helping those in need is a guiding principle in my life.
- I should make sacrifices of my own—time, money, or other things—to help people in need.
- I feel a moral duty to help those who are struggling.
- I should pursue what is best for me and my family even if it comes at the expense of people in need (reverse coded).

p. 109 These four items were designed to capture an underlying propensity to prioritize helping those in need, gauging attitudes about prosocial $\hookrightarrow$ behavior aimed at strangers rather than kin. Each statement is laden with normative language, orienting individuals to evaluate helping behavior within the framework of what is right and good (Bicchieri, 2016; Thøgersen, 2006). Although these measures most accurately represent the strength of personal norms, when aggregated together they provide insight into group descriptive or injunctive norms as well (Thøgersen, 2006).

I hoped that these items would load together to measure a single concept and the empirical evidence suggests they do. A Cronbach’s alpha test confirms that the battery has high internal consistency both in the sample as a whole ($\alpha = 0.71$) and across groups (Asian $\alpha = 0.71$, Black $\alpha = 0.66$, Latino $\alpha = 0.68$, White $\alpha = 0.78$). I average responses to these four items, producing a single score for each respondent that indicates the strength of his or her personal helping hands norm. Ranging from 0 to 4, high scores on this scale identify individuals who have strong prescriptive commitments to help those in need; low scores represent individuals with weak commitments to the helping hands norm. I call this measure the *helping hands index*.

Figure 5.2 shows the distribution for each racial group with respect to the helping hands norm. Low values along the x axis represent weak commitments to the norm, while higher values represent stronger commitments. The y axis plots within-group proportions, and a vertical dashed line indicates the mean for each group.

The results show distributions that are skewed to the left, suggesting a general endorsement of the norm both in the sample as a whole and across racial groups. Fewer than 4% of the entire sample register a score below 1,

indicating they “somewhat disagree” to “strongly disagree” with the provided statements. Furthermore, the sample mean of 2.55 is statistically distinct from the scale’s midpoint. However, compared to the honoring ancestors norm, commitments to help those in need are tempered. In chapter 4, I showed that nearly 50% of the PSNS sample scored between the top two categories of the honoring ancestors index (figure 4.2); comparatively, only 20% of the sample register the same strong commitment to the helping hands norm. Furthermore, the helping hands index sample mean is statistically lower than that of the honoring ancestors index ($p < 0.01$). The results suggest that while many Americans seem to embrace the helping hands norm, a commitment to honor the struggles and sacrifices of those in the past is more widespread than is a commitment to help those in need.

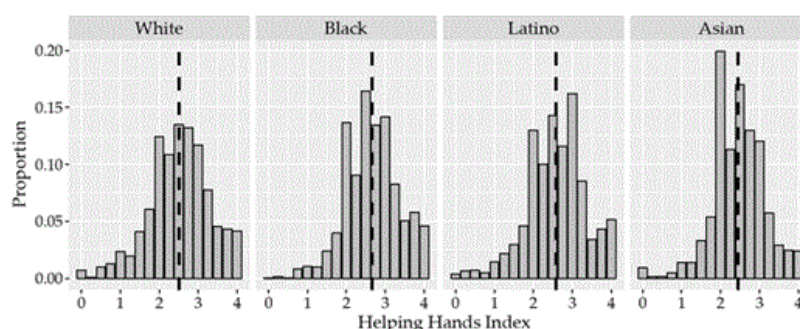


Figure 5.2 Distribution of helping hands strength

p. 110 Turning to each of the individual groups, the results show variation with respect to endorsements of the helping hands norm. Of the four groups, Black Americans demonstrate the strongest commitment to helping those in need, with a sample mean of 2.66, followed by Latinos at 2.59, White Americans at 2.51, and Asians at 2.45. All sample means are statistically distinct from one another at levels of $p < 0.07$. Within-item variation also appears across groups (appendix C, figure C.3). For instance, 28% of Black Americans and 24% of Latinos strongly agree that helping those in need is a guiding principle in their lives, compared to only 16% of Whites and 14% of Asians. These results suggest that moderate but statistically significant differences appear across the groups with respect to the strength of the norm. Many believe that helping those in need is normatively required of them, but Black Americans are most likely to embrace this commitment.

How do Americans go about expressing these commitments to help the needy? A question from the PSNS allows us to explore this. Respondents were asked to “think again about people who are in need. What do you think are the best ways to take care of these people?” The question was followed by a list of eight response options presented in random order with the addition of “none” and “other” anchored at the end. Drawing from my qualitative interviews, these response options fell into three theoretical categories: political expressions of the helping hands norm, charitable or personal service expressions, and religious expressions. For the political expressions, respondents could indicate that the best way to help those in need was through voting or engaging in politics to change policy, giving money to political causes, or participating in political organizations. For the charitable and personal service expression, respondents could select giving money to charitable causes, participating in charitable organizations, or acts of service to strangers. Finally, for the religious expression of the norm, respondents could select praying for those in need or helping those in need find a religious community.⁵

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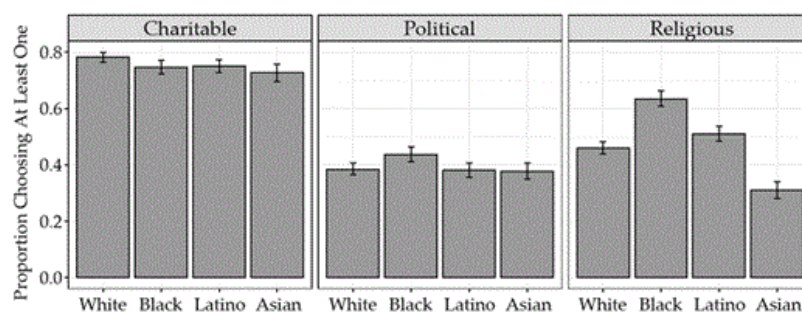


Figure 5.3 Ways to help those in need

Figure 5.3 plots the proportion of each racial group that selected at least one behavior from each of the three categories. Eighty percent confidence intervals surround the point estimates, indicating roughly a 0.05 statistical *t*-test between groups (Cumming and Finch, 2005; Schenker and Gentleman, 2001). The plots show that of the three categories, charitable activities are the more common behaviors tied to the helping hands norm for all four groups. Seventy-eight percent of White Americans, 75% of Black Americans and Latinos, and 73% of Asian Americans suggest charitable activity is the best way to care for the needy. White Americans, however, are statistically more likely than the three minority groups to select at least one charitable activity as an ideal way to help those in need ($p < 0.05$).

Wider variation appears with respect to the connection between religious behaviors and the helping hands norm. Here, 63% of Black Americans, 51% of Latinos, 44% of White Americans, and 31% of Asian Americans connect at least one religious behavior to helping those in need. All group point estimates are statistically distinct from one another ($p < 0.05$) and substantively quite large.

Finally, all four groups are significantly less likely to select at least one political activity as a way to help those in need compared to charitable activities, but the connection between political activities and prosocial helping is still relatively common. More than a third of the sample identify political participation as part of the helping hands norm, but variation occurs with respect to the prevalence of this connection. As hypothesized, Black Americans are significantly more likely than the three other groups to select at least one political behavior as a way to care for those in need. The other three groups—Asian, Latino, and White Americans—are statistically indistinguishable. Forty-four percent of Black Americans connect political involvement to the helping hands norm, compared to 38% of Asian, Latino, and White respondents. This six-point gap between Black Americans and other racial groups is statistically significant at $p < 0.05$.

These results only partially confirm expectations. While Black Americans are statistically more likely than other groups to connect at least one political behavior to the helping hands norm, there is no variation between Asian, Latino, and White Americans. However, variation may still appear with respect to the specific political behaviors attached to the helping hands norm for each group.

To examine this possibility, figure 5.4 shows the proportion of each racial group selecting specific political behaviors associated with the helping hands norm: vote or engage in politics to change policy, give money to political causes, and participate in political organizations.⁶ Although some nuance emerges with respect to how groups go about bundling political behaviors into the helping hands norm, significantly less variation appears than with respect to the honoring ancestors norm (figure 4.4). Across groups, the most common political behavior associated with helping those in need is to “vote or engage in politics to change policy.” Black Americans are more likely than the other racial minority groups to consider this activity an ideal way to help those in need. Forty one percent of Black Americans select this option as the best way to help the needy, compared to 35% of Latinos, 34% of Asian Americans, and 37% of White Americans ($p < 0.05$ for the Black/Latino-Asian comparison and $p < 0.1$ for the Black/White comparison).

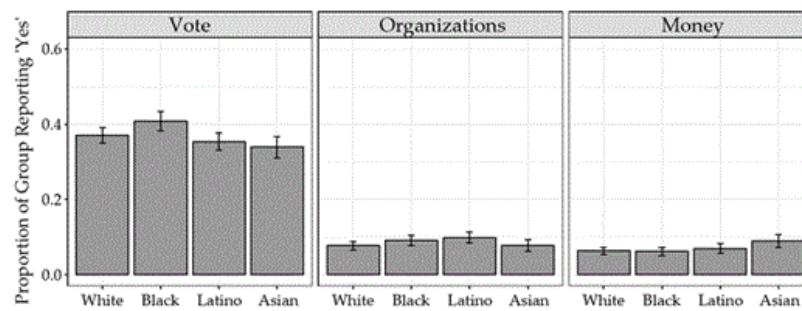


Figure 5.4 Political expression of helping hands by group

p. 113 Differences in the other two political behaviors show only marginally significant variation across groups. Latinos are most likely to report participating in political organizations as a way to help those in need at 10%, compared to 9% of Black Americans and 8% of White and Asian Americans. The two-point gap between Latinos on one hand and White and Asian Americans on the other is substantively small and only marginally significant ($p < 0.1$). Finally, Asian Americans are significantly more likely than both White and Black Americans to report giving money to political causes as a way to help those in need ($p < 0.05$) and marginally more likely than Latinos to do so ($p < 0.1$).

Similar to the honoring ancestors norm, then, the results show that a number of behaviors can and do get bundled into the helping hands norm. Americans can show compliance with the norm through charitable, religious, and even political behaviors, but some groups are more likely than others to endorse one way of helping compared to another. Although the variation is less pronounced than with the honoring ancestors norm, White Americans are more likely than racial minorities to endorse charitable giving as the best way to help those in need. Black Americans are more likely than other groups to believe political activity is the best way to care for those in need. Furthermore, specific racial minority groups are occasionally more likely to attach political behaviors to the helping hands norm. This variation, though, is significantly muted compared to the honoring ancestors norm explored in the previous chapter. Analyses of the PSNS there revealed relatively large gaps of up to 15 percentage points between groups with respect to the propensity to couple political participation to the honoring ancestors norm in general and to specific political behaviors in particular.

The Political Helping Index

We can combine the three political items connected to helping those in need to make a single measure gauging the strength of a personal political expression of the helping hands norm for each respondent. I assign a point for each political act an individual selected, then add together these three items and rescale the measure from 0 to 1. Zero signifies the individual did not select any political acts as ways to help those in need, and one means they selected all of the political items when describing the best ways to care for the needy. The distribution of this measure, which I call the *political helping index*, is plotted in figure 5.5 for each of the four racial groups. ↴

p. 114

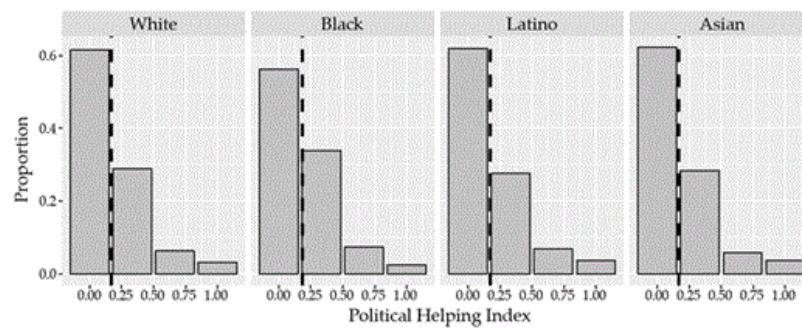


Figure 5.5 Distribution of the political helping index by group

The figures show distributions heavily scaled to the right, suggesting a strong connection between the helping hands norm and political activity are relatively rare in the United States. Only 3%–4% of any racial group connect all three political behaviors to taking care of those in need, while fully 62% of White Americans, Asian Americans, and Latinos and 56% of Black Americans make no connection between political participation and helping those in need.⁷

The relative rarity of a strong political helping hands norm does not suggest that it is inconsequential for political participation. Rather, high-cost grassroots political actions—the types of behaviors most commonly coupled with the helping hands norm during interviews—are relatively unusual in the United States, suggesting the variable that explains these behaviors should also be relatively rare. However, the consistent means in the political helping index across groups ($x = 0.17$ – 0.19) suggest that this variable may be less important for explaining variation across groups than the honoring ancestors norm. As a result, we may find that a political interpretation of the helping hands norm is important for predicting engagement in politics among individuals but does relatively less to explain across-group differences in engagement.

p. 115 I will use the political helping index later to predict engagement in politics, so it is important we confirm that this newly constructed measure is distinct from other known political variables. If the political helping index is simply a reiteration of other measures already known to matter in the political world, it does little to grow our understanding of the dynamics of politics. For instance, critics might wonder whether the political helping index simply captures one's interest in political affairs rather than measuring the unique bundling of the helping hands norm with political behavior or may be concerned that the political helping index is a reiteration of the well-known concept of racial linked fate among low-status group members. Before we start using our measure to predict political behavior, then, we want to establish that the political helping index has *discriminant validity* from other possible confounds.

I examine the relationship between the political helping index and four political variables—political interest, racial linked fate, and Democratic versus Republican partisanship compared to independents—as I did for the political ancestors index using Pearson's correlation coefficients.⁸ I also examine the relationship between the political helping index and the political ancestors index to further determine whether the two measures capture distinct norm expressions rather than simply a latent interest in political participation.

Table 5.1 shows the results of these analyses. The tests confirm that while the political helping index is correlated with each alternative measure of political and group investment, the relationships are far from perfect. Rather, most of the variables are only weakly correlated with the political helping index, providing us with confirmation that our newly constructed measure of helping others through political involvement makes an independent contribution to our understanding of orientations to the political system. That is, the political helping index measures something distinct, although related to, other known measures of psychological investment in politics and one's racial group.

Table 5.1 Relationship between the political helping norm and political dispositions

	Asian	Black	Latino	White
Political interest	0.39	0.38	0.37	0.36
	(418)	(1,000)	(995)	(999)
Republican partisanship	0.16	0.03	0.06	0.09
	(390)	(140)	(321)	(571)
Democratic partisanship	0.22	0.15	0.25	0.36
	(640)	(897)	(720)	(466)
Racial linked fate	0.13	0.19	0.16	0.01
	(1,013)	(986)	(988)	(990)
Political ancestors index	0.51	0.52	0.55	0.49
	(1,020)	(1,001)	(1,000)	(1,000)

Notes: Table entry is the Pearson's correlation coefficient; number of observations appears in parentheses. Political interest is measured using a 4-point scale; Democratic and Republican partisanship are 4-point scales where 0 represents independents, 1 represents leaners, 2 represents weak identifiers, and 3 represents strong identifiers; racial linked fate is a 5-point scale; the political ancestors index is a 4-point scale developed in the previous chapter.

p. 116 Specifically, political interest is positively related to the political helping index for each of the four groups, with an r ranging from 0.36 (White) to 0.39 (Asian). This positive relationship suggests that those with a strong political helping index are also more likely to be interested in politics, an expected outcome. It also provides confirmation that the two measures capture distinct variations in attitudes, giving us confidence that the political helping index is not simply an indication of those high in political interest.

Similarly, the strength of Democratic and Republican partisanship is positively related to the political helping index for each of the four groups, although the relationship tends to be stronger for Democratic partisans. While a strong Republican identifier is more likely than a partisan independent to see helping those in need as requiring political action, the relationship ranges from only 0.03 (Black) to 0.16 (Asian). Among Democrats, the strength of partisanship is positively related at rates of 0.15 (Black) to 0.36 (White). The relatively stronger connection between Democratic partisanship and the helping hands norm, especially among White Americans, is expected given the theoretical centering of structural disadvantage in the party's current platform. I have argued that perceptions of and experiences with structural disadvantage within a group help to couple the helping hands norm with political participation. White coalitions within the Democratic Party tend to be lowstatus members of the American social system on dimensions other than race (e.g., women, LGBTQ individuals, low socioeconomic status individuals) and as a result, may be more likely to perceive and experience such disadvantage. Alternatively, the relationship may capture the underlying ideology of the party that centers structural solutions for problems like poverty and discrimination.

Racial linked fate is similarly related to the political helping index but only weakly so and at rates variable across groups. The strength of this relationship increases as we move from the highest-status racial group (White Americans, $r = 0.01$) to the lowest (Black Americans, $r = 0.19$).

p. 117 Finally, the results show a correlation between the political helping index and the political ancestors index ranging from 0.49 (White) to 0.55 (Latino). Although larger than the other correlation coefficients in the table, the relationship still falls well below the conventional threshold of 0.85 for determining discriminant validity (Campbell and Fiske, 1959). Collectively, the results confirm that while other variables of political and group interests are statistically related to the political helping norm, they are not the same thing. Rather, the political helping index introduces a unique concept with discriminant validity, one we'll use in the next two chapters to predict and explain political involvement in the United States.

Racial Group Embeddedness and the Political Helping Norm

The racialized norms model suggests that group-based norms will be most evident in highly racialized contexts. It is within these settings that norm signal is the strongest and enforcement is most potent (Larson and Lewis, 2017; Oliver, 2010). The results so far suggest that only moderate variation exists across groups with respect to the political behaviors bundled into the helping hands norm, but does racial embeddedness intensify this variation?

I use the PSNS to examine whether geographic, social, or psychological embeddedness in a racial group leads to a weaker or stronger interpretation of the political helping norm. I rely on the same measures developed and discussed in the previous chapter. Geographic embeddedness measures the degree to which a respondent's census block is coracial. Social embeddedness represents the proportion of respondents' close social ties that are coracial. And psychological embeddedness is a measure of in-group feelings of closeness.

I use four linear regression models—one for each racial group—to estimate the relationship between group embeddedness and a political expression of the helping hands norm. For each of these regressions, the dependent variable is the political helping index, and the primary independent variables are the measures of geographic, social, and psychological coracial embeddedness, scaled from 0 to 1. I include controls in these models for variables that likely covary with racial context and may be associated with helping norms: census tract median income; the proportion of a respondent's census tract older than age twenty-five who has at least a high school degree; the proportion of citizens who are either naturalized or noncitizens; and individual-level controls for income, education, and nativity status.

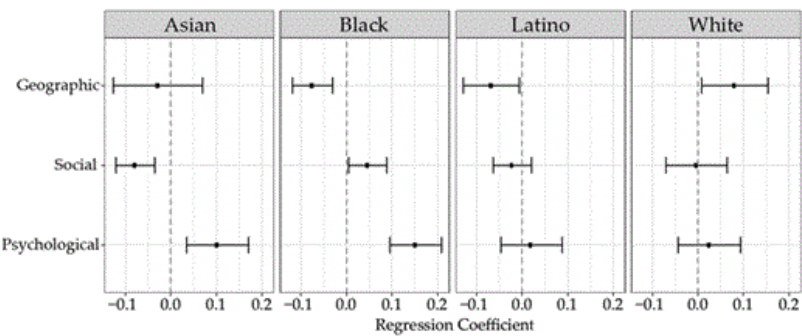


Figure 5.6 Relationship between racial group embeddedness and the political helping index

Notes: The figure plots the results of four multivariate linear regression models, one for each group. Point estimates show the effect of going from the smallest to the largest category in the independent variable, and 90% confidence intervals are plotted around point estimates. The dependent variable, the political helping index, is scaled from 0 to 1, with 1 representing the strongest possible commitment to helping those in need through political involvement.

Figure 5.6 plots the coefficients for geographic, social, and psychological coracial embeddedness, drawn from each of the four linear regression models available in appendix C, table C.4. By including each of the

embeddedness measures in a single model, these coefficients estimate the independent effect of each level of context on the political expression of the norm. Since these independent variables are scaled from 0 to 1, we can interpret the plotted points as the estimated full-scale change in the strength of the political helping index when moving from the lowest to the highest level of coracial embeddedness.

The results show that the strength of the political helping index often varies with racial embeddedness, especially for Asian and Black Americans. Specifically, social embeddedness has a negative effect on the strength of the political helping norm for Asian Americans, but psychological embeddedness has a positive effect. Maintaining a network of close ties that is entirely coracial versus not doing so produces an 8% decrease in the strength of the political ancestors norm among Asian Americans ($p < 0.05$). In contrast, psychological embeddedness in the group—that is, a feeling of closeness with other Asian American panethnics—increases the political helping index for Asian Americans ↘ by 10% ($p < 0.05$). Geographic coracial embeddedness, however, has no discernible effect on Asian American beliefs about whether the helping hands norm demands political participation.

For Black Americans, both social and psychological embeddedness lead to an increase in a political expression of the helping hands norm. Specifically, psychological closeness with other Black Americans increases the strength of the political helping index by 15%, and coracial social embeddedness creates a 5% increase in the politicization of the norm ($p < 0.05$ and $p < 0.1$, respectively). Geographic embeddedness, however, is negatively associated with the politicization of the norm, producing a 7% decrease in the strength of the political helping index, an unexpected finding.

While racial embeddedness—especially social and psychological embeddedness—affects the strength of the political helping norm for Asian and Black Americans, it has little effect on the dispositions of Latino and White Americans. For both groups, social and psychological embeddedness are statistically unrelated to a political expression of the helping hands norm, and geographic embeddedness is related to a marginally significant—but contrasting—effect. For Latinos, increased geographic embeddedness decreases the strength of the political helping index by 6% ($p < 0.1$). For White Americans, geographic coracial embeddedness increases the political expression of the norm by 8% ($p < 0.1$).

In many ways, the results mirror the broader pattern of variation with respect to a political expression of the norm across groups: while some variation exists in the racialization of the norm, it is significantly smaller and less consistent than what we observed for the honoring ancestors norm in the previous chapter. While racial embeddedness shapes the propensity to link the helping hands norm to political participation among Black and Asian Americans, it often does so in contrasting directions and with less potency than for the honoring ancestors norm, where effect sizes were often between ten and twenty points. Thus, while a politicization for the helping hands norm does seem to vary across racial contexts, the degree of the variation is less pronounced.

Helping Those in Need through Political Action

Beliefs about deservingness, propensities toward empathy, and the effect of both on prosocial policy positions have held growing interest among ↘ political scientists in recent years (e.g., Cramer, 2016; Gilens, 2009; Piston, 2018; Sirin, Valentino, and Villalobos, 2016a). These scholars argue that race, group position, and perceptions about who the government is inclined to help influence a range of political attitudes, including partisanship, redistribution, and immigration. To this literature, I add the measurement of a new political attitude: a normative belief that political participation is a way to help those in need.

My results demonstrate that prescriptive beliefs about the importance of helping those in need are quite common in the United States, echoing those who have engaged with this question from a policy perspective

(Gilens, 2009; Piston, 2018). However, the behaviors associated with helping—that is, how one goes about showing compliance with the prescriptive norm—are many. Helping those in need can take the form of charitable action, religious work, and even political involvement. Furthermore, the likelihood of elevating political participation as a way to help those most in need varies slightly across groups, with Black Americans in particular, and minority Americans in general, more likely than White respondents to make this connection. Drawing from a rich literature in social psychology on prosocial behavior, I argue that this variation comes from differences in status and resources between the groups that alter perceptions of deservingness and the causes of suffering.

The results also indicate that racial variation in the political helping index is significantly smaller than what we observed for the political ancestors norm discussed in the previous chapter. This finding suggests that while a prescriptive commitment to help those in need through political action may shape motivations to engage in politics broadly, it may be less important for explaining across-group likelihood to engage. I turn next to examining this possibility, determining whether our newly constructed measures of political social norms—the political helping index and political ancestors index—explain turnout in large, salient elections above and beyond extant theories.

Notes

1. But see Lichter, Shanahan, and Gardner (2002), who suggest that one prosocial behavior in particular—volunteering—may be lower as a result of childhood exposure to poverty.
2. A discussion and presentation of these analyses is available in the online appendix (see appendix A for the URL). Work on over-time trends has noted, however, that this orientation among Black Americans is declining (Hunt, 2007; Smith, 2014b).
3. The online appendix shows point estimates. Bobo and Kluegel (1997), Kinder and Kam (2010), and Peffley, Hurwitz, and Sniderman (1997) provide just a few examples of how this measure has been used elsewhere.
4. The Hart-Celler Immigration and Nationality Act, which took effect in 1968, opened up immigration from Asia for the first time in nearly a century and produced a wave of Asian immigrants who today comprise the majority of the group's members (Masuoka and Junn, 2013). The policy change built a clear selection bias into its priorities regarding who could gain legal permanent residency in the United States. Rather than quotas based on race and ethnicity as had been the case in the past, the new immigration system prioritized the entrance of highly skilled workers and those seeking family reunification. As a result, the vast majority of Asian migrants arriving in the United States over the past half century have been selected precisely because they are highly skilled and well educated (Junn, 2008; Masuoka and Junn, 2013).
5. Complete wording for the response items is available in appendix A. While the list of options is not designed to capture *all* the ways Americans might help those in need, an examination of the “none” and “other” response categories suggests it does capture most of the ways people act on this norm. Across the whole sample, 11% of respondents selected “none,” and only 4% choose “other.”
6. Similar breakdowns for the charitable and religious interpretations of the helping hands norm are available in appendix C, figure C.4.
7. Additional tests of within-group variation with respect to gender, age, socioeconomic resources, and generational status are available in the online appendix. These results show relatively little within-group variation with the exception of socioeconomic resources and age for Black Americans, gender for Latinos, and generational status for White Americans. I also break down the relationships for the largest within-race ethnic groups for Latinos and Asian Americans in the online appendix. These groups collectively make up about/at least half of their respective racial group.
8. Strength of partisanship is measured by combining a set of (up to three) branching questions designed to sort respondents into a spectrum of independents (0), partisan leaners (1), weak partisans (2), and strong partisans (3). Political interest is measured by asking respondents how interested they are in politics and public affairs; respondents are provided with four response options ranging from not at all interested (0) to very interested (3). Because I purchased the political interest variable from the survey company GfK after the study was completed, the off-GfK panel Asian American respondents are excluded from this analysis. Finally, racial linked fate is measured by asking respondents to what degree they agree with the statement “What happens generally to (White/Black/Asian/Latino or Hispanic) people in this country will affect what happens to me,” with the racial category generated in the question matching the respondents' self-identification. Response options range from strongly disagree (0) to strongly agree (4).